

British Museum - Mesopotamia

Official textual snapshot for RAG ingestion

Background

Mesopotamia is the region between the Tigris and Euphrates rivers. From around 6000 BC, farming settlements developed into towns and cities. Sumerians lived mainly in the south, Akkadians and Babylonians in central Mesopotamia, and Assyrians in the north.

Writing and learning

Writing began in Sumerian cities around 3200 BC. Pictograms gradually developed into cuneiform wedge-shaped signs. Clay tablets recorded administration, literature, astronomy, medicine, mathematics, letters and histories. Ashurbanipal assembled a major library at Nineveh.

Technology and craft

Mesopotamian specialists produced pottery, glass, metalwork, stone sculpture, cylinder seals, musical instruments and jewellery. Many raw materials, especially metals and stone, had to be imported.

Religion

Mesopotamian religion involved many gods and goddesses, temples, offerings, festivals and divine images. Temples were major religious and economic centres.

Room 56

Room 56 covers Mesopotamia from 6000 to 1500 BC, including agriculture, writing, technology, Sumer, Akkad, Babylon and objects from the Royal Cemetery at Ur. The Standard of Ur is a principal highlight.

Room 55

Room 55 covers Mesopotamia from 1500 to 539 BC, including Kassite and Neo-Babylonian history, Assyria, palace objects, boundary stones and tablets from Ashurbanipal's library.

Assyria - Nimrud

Rooms 7-8 display reliefs from Ashurnasirpal II's Northwest Palace at Nimrud. The reliefs depict military campaigns, ritual scenes, protective beings and royal hunting.

Key object: K.3375

Tablet K.3375 is associated with the Epic of Gilgamesh and Ashurbanipal's library. It is displayed in Room 55, case 16.

Official sources

<https://www.britishmuseum.org/collection/galleries/mesopotamia>

<https://www.britishmuseum.org/collection/galleries/mesopotamia-1500-539-bc>

<https://www.britishmuseum.org/collection/galleries/assyria-nimrud>

https://www.britishmuseum.org/collection/object/W_K-3375

https://www.britishmuseum.org/collection/object/W_1938-0520-1

https://www.britishmuseum.org/sites/default/files/2019-09/Visit_Mesopotamia_KS2b.pdf